

C01 · KNOWING

The Stranger Across From Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Stranger Across From Me

For a few minutes you are a courteous stranger with a good ear, not a partner with a file.

1. In silence, about 5 minutes, each of you writes three questions a polite stranger could ask this person. Mix them: a memory of a year or room when they felt most like themselves; a habit a new friend would misread, and what that misreading gets wrong; a belief they rarely say in a group, asked so they can decline.
2. It qualifies only if it needs no shared history and cannot be answered in one word. Tear up anything worn out this month, and anything that is a flirt-test or a cross-examination.
3. Ask one at a time. One follow-up may ask to see the answer more clearly. It may not corner it. A declined question is a complete answer. Then swap.

Name one thing you had not known how to ask. Leave the rest on the paper.

Either of you may pass the whole card. Passing is a finished visit.



C02 · KNOWING

The Life You've Never Told Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Life You've Never Told Me

One episode the relationship has not heard, told once, without a diagnosis.

1. Alone, about 5 minutes, jot four anchors, not a script. Place: where the bodies were. The turn: the moment the day changed, in one sentence. One formative person inside this episode. What still echoes in an ordinary week now.
2. Decide who tells first. Set 8 to 10 minutes. The teller speaks or reads without interruption.
3. The listener keeps the episode in view. Do not correct a date, diagnose a family, or rush to why the teller is this way. If a matching story rises, put a hand on the table or on your own knee and leave it there until the timer is yours.
4. Swap with the same clock. A matching story after both turns is optional.

The listener says one concrete detail they are keeping, not a moral. The teller may correct that detail.

If the episode is too live tonight, say so and choose another, or pass the card.



C03 · KNOWING

The Things Nobody Thinks to Ask

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Things Nobody Thinks to Ask

Three questions you have never asked this person. Leave favorite colors in the other room.

1. Each of you writes three questions you have never asked. Spread them across more than one kind: belief, habit, memory, preference, private thought. You do not have to hit all five kinds tonight.
2. Examples you may discard: a money rule absorbed before you could argue with it; what your hands do in the first minute you are alone in a kitchen; a hallway that still belongs to a version of you this relationship has not met; the texture of quiet you want after a loud day.
3. Ask one. The answer can be short. One curious follow-up is allowed. Advice is not.
4. Decline any question. Then swap until each written question has been asked or retired.

Each of you names the question you are glad existed, even if you declined it.

A declined question is complete. Passing the card is complete.



C04 · KNOWING

The Museum of Me

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Museum of Me

You curate four pieces of a life. Your partner is a visitor, not a critic.

1. Each curator prepares four exhibits. Every label has three lines: what it is, which stretch of life it holds, and why it is in the collection. A mug, a person, a song, or a missed train can be an exhibit.
2. If all four are achievements, replace one with something ordinary, odd, or unfinished.
3. The curator speaks the labels in their own order. After each exhibit the visitor may ask one question that asks to see the piece more clearly. A question that replaces the piece with the visitor's theory does not count. Ask another, or ask none.
4. Then the visitor becomes the curator.

The visitor names the exhibit they will remember, in the curator's words, and the curator may correct the label.

Any exhibit may stay in storage. Say "not on view" and continue.



C05 · KNOWING

The Opinion I Changed

The Art of Really Knowing Someone

The Opinion I Changed

How you actually change your mind, told without a trophy.

1. Choose who goes first by appetite, not by the more impressive conversion. Set about 8 minutes.
2. The teller speaks three beats in order. The old sentence. What shifted it. How they tend to change.
3. The listener does not prosecute the current view and does not applaud a flattering conversion. They ask only: "What was the hardest part to let go?"
4. After the answer, the listener reflects the growth line in one sentence. The teller corrects it if needed. That correction is the listening. Then swap, with the same time.

If the reflection was fair, the teller says so in a few words. Stop there.

If you have no change you want to tell, pass. Passing is a complete card.



C06 · COURAGE

The Uncomfortable Truth

Vulnerability and the Courage to Be Seen

The Uncomfortable Truth

One hard admission, then 3 quiet minutes before anyone repairs it.

1. Say your pause phrase. Choose who speaks first. The second turn gets the same clock.
2. A quiet minute, then one difficult admission. If the listener speaks, the only line is, "I'm taking this in."
3. When you stop, start 3 minutes. No fix, bright side, cross-examination, or matching confession. If the quiet feels like a wall, repeat that sentence only.
4. Ask for one short reply and name the kind: what you heard, one question, or an idea. Or end the turn. Then swap.

One truth each, under this rule, finishes the standard sitting.

Do not build a case against your partner. Ongoing harm, abuse, or a safety problem stops this frame. Ordinary responsibility resumes.

A pass or a smaller admission is a finished turn. The pause phrase can stop you or send you to an easier truth.



C07 · COURAGE

The Permission Slip

Vulnerability and the Courage to Be Seen

The Permission Slip

Sign permission to be unfinished in one specific way. Your partner may hear the sentence. They do not grant it.

1. Glance at the menu or ignore it: imperfect, playful, uncertain, ambitious, needy, emotionally open. Draft in silence.
2. Standard shape: I give myself permission to be [one way] when [a real situation], and I will stop requiring [one self-demand] of myself this week.
3. Read it to yourself. If their body, time, or money is the object, keep the permission and set the request aside. A later request can be declined.
4. Read aloud only if you want to. The witness says what they heard, then stops. They do not rewrite it or grant it. Then swap. A card may stay unread.

Done when each person who wanted a slip has signed one or chosen not to show it.

You may pass, pocket the card, or change the word. One honest permission is enough.



C08 · COURAGE

Confession Without Consequence

Vulnerability and the Courage to Be Seen

Confession Without Consequence

Offer one harmless embarrassment, regret, insecurity, or private oddity. Curious questions only.

1. Name the four kinds. Agree a pause word. "Different item" is enough.
2. Before the story, say, "This is mine to tell, and it is harmless," and name the kind. If you cannot, it leaves the game. Tell it in 3 to 5 minutes.
3. Two curious questions, not a case and not advice. A declined question is replaced, or you stop at one.
4. Close the turn. Swap with equal time. The second person may pass, and does not owe a more dramatic kind.

Done when each allowed offer, or a pass, has been heard inside the rule.

If harm shows up, say, "This leaves the game." Abuse, a betrayal they have a right to know, an undisclosed health or legal risk, harm to someone else, infidelity, and illegal acts stay outside.

Either of you may pass or decline a question. The pause word changes the item.



C09 · COURAGE

When I Feel Small

Vulnerability and the Courage to Be Seen

When I Feel Small

Name when you feel inadequate or overlooked, and the response that has actually helped.

1. About 8 private minutes. Two recognizable situations. For each, one helping behavior and one that bounces. "Love me more" is too vague. Unsure is allowed. A guess is labeled a guess.
2. Share one situation and both responses, as written. Your partner repeats the help in their words, then says can, sometimes, or not really. No demonstration unless you ask.
3. Correct them if they polished your sentence into a nicer one. Then swap. Stop after one situation each.

Done when the help has been repeated and answered with a real limit.

If the situation is a harmful pattern, they restate and do not cross-examine. Stopping it is a separate conversation.

You may pass, shrink a situation, or leave what bounces unspoken. A pass finishes the turn.



C10 · COURAGE

No Armor Tonight

Vulnerability and the Courage to Be Seen

No Armor Tonight

For a short window, set down joke-as-cover, defense, and the impressive answer. One modest topic, spoken plainly.

1. Say the topic in one sentence. Set about 15 minutes, and split it in half.
2. Talk about the feeling. If a joke ducks it, say, "Let me try that plainly," and restate one sentence. Your partner does not catch it for you. A delighted laugh may stay.
3. At the half, the listener offers one feeling of their own about what they heard. Not a score of how bare you were.
4. Swap for the same length. End when the timer ends, or sooner. There is no armor score.

A plain sentence is enough. After the timer, the evening may be funny again.

An insult is not unarmored truth. If the topic becomes harm or safety, stop the style game and deal with it directly.

Either of you may end early or trade for a milder topic.



∩ C11 · CLOSENESS

Four Minutes of Forever

The Science and Experience of Closeness

Four Minutes of Forever

Sit face to face. Look toward each other's eyes and stay with your own sensation.

1. Timer in reach. A raised hand, or the word stop, ends it. Optional line: we look, we notice, we can stop.
2. Four minutes. Blinks are allowed. Glance away to settle, then return. Do not decode the other face.
3. When time ends, or a hand or the word stop ends it, look away on purpose. Early still counts.
4. One notice each, from your own side only. One sentence. Do not interpret your partner's face.

The standard is four minutes inside about fifteen. Ending early completes the session.

Skip this if anyone has been drinking, or if it is a dare. Stop for dizziness, panic, or a wish to get out. A long look is not consent to touch or sex.

Passing finishes the session. Without gaze, attend to your own hands or to sound. You do not have to take hold.



∩ C12 · CLOSENESS

Breathe With Me

The Science and Experience of Closeness

Breathe With Me

Sit together and let breathing do what it does. Your own rate is the whole technique.

1. Seats first. Say: we are not trying to breathe alike. We are sitting here until the breath does whatever it does. The word here is optional.
2. Start six minutes. Quit performing a slow breath. Do not correct the other person.
3. Sighs and shifts are allowed. Move if you are in pain. Eyes may stay open.
4. Wait a moment when it ends. Two sentences each: what you noticed in yourself, then one thing you could point to.

The standard sit is six minutes, inside about fifteen. Claim no sync.

Never restrict the breath, and never hold it. Stop for pain, dizziness, or distress. Agree any hand before the timer. This is not a prelude to sex.

Speak or stop at any time. Stopping is success. A recline is a full version.



∩ C13 · CLOSENESS

The Listening Experiment

The Science and Experience of Closeness

The Listening Experiment

Uninterrupted speech, then the meaning returned, then a minute to correct it. You swap with equal time.

1. Name a finishable topic, and say if it is good news. The listener may decline what they cannot hold. The second turn is equal.
2. Six uninterrupted minutes. You need not fill them. No advice, no matching story, and no question during the turn.
3. About two minutes: I heard, for the content, and it sounded like you felt, for the feeling. On grief, worry, or anger, no silver lining.
4. One correction minute. The listener may ask what they missed, and does not argue. Swap. The second speaker still has six minutes.

Talk about the process if you want. Advice waits for a separate yes.

A reflection is not agreement, and it is not therapy. If the story is harm, leave the exercise. Being heard is not immunity.

A pause for a break is allowed. Declining the topic, or stopping, completes the session.



∩ C14 · CLOSENESS

The Language of Touch

The Science and Experience of Closeness

The Language of Touch

Mark the menu in private. Play only the overlap you both called welcome tonight.

1. Unseen, mark hand, shoulder, upper back, linked arms, knees, forearm, hair, face, and one nonsexual form you add: welcome tonight, not tonight, or leave out.
2. Play only the overlap. An added form needs a yes from both. No overlap: describe a future welcome, and do not demonstrate it.
3. Before contact, the receiver sets pressure, place, and duration. The giver follows and does not wander or add a place.
4. Stop, a lifted hand, or moving away retires it. If it finishes, one word: comfort, affection, neutral, or stop. Then swap.

Four is a ceiling. Read the words back. Welcomes expire when you get up.

This stays nonsexual. Do not ask why, and do not lobby a not tonight. A mark is not consent past this list, and it ends with the evening.

You may describe instead of touching, and skip the explanation. A pass on the swap is a decline.



∩ C15 · CLOSENESS

The Sixty-Second Embrace

The Science and Experience of Closeness

The Sixty-Second Embrace

One embrace, errand set down, only while it stays comfortable. Sixty seconds is a proposal, not a dose.

1. Usual hug first, if you have one, then step apart. Ask: full, side by side, or seated.
2. Both must say yes for up to sixty seconds. Either may leave sooner. A no means another form, a hand-hold, or a stop.
3. Before contact: I'm going to step back. No errand talk, no rocking, no harder squeeze as the timer runs, no pinning.
4. That phrase ends it at once. Early is complete, including at ten seconds. At the alarm, say it and step apart.
5. One sentence each on how it differed from the routine hug, or from having none.

A second minute only if both of you ask after you have stepped apart.

This stays nonsexual. Name desire and leave it. Do not hug toward a truce. Every second can be declined.

Stopping before contact completes the session. Skip illness, heat, or a fight still open.



C46 · STORY

The First Chapter

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The First Chapter

Write the beginning twice, apart, before either voice can steer it.

1. 10 quiet minutes. Five lines each: where it begins for you, and a different day is allowed; what you were unsure of; one detail later tellings have polished; what you guessed the other person felt; one fact you still do not know, which may stay private.
2. One person reads the five lines. The listener does not correct a name or improve a line. Private marks only: same memory, news to me, I remember it differently. Then switch.
3. Now talk. Say both beginnings and what each is counting. One curious question for the news. Set disagreements side by side, and do not average them.

Optional: one agreed fact and one uncertainty you will leave in. Or name that uncertainty and stop.

Stop if a live argument about faithfulness is waiting. Have it in plain time.

Skip any stretch you do not want replayed. No reason is required. You may stop after one scene.



C47 · STORY

The Moments You Didn’t Know Mattered

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The Moments You Didn't Know Mattered

A small act you carried at a size the giver never heard. Not a performance of gratitude.

1. 8 quiet minutes. Up to five small items: a sentence, a chore, a look, a restraint, a practical save. Three should be smaller than a gift or a trip. One honest item is enough.
2. Trade one at a time: where you were, what they did, and why it stayed. The receiver lets it land and does not improve the story. One curious question. They may take a minute. A different memory does not cancel yours.
3. Switch one for one. No matching size is required. Two spoken and the rest private is complete.
4. Agreed pairs only, in two columns: what was done, and what it meant. Shrink a swollen sentence back to the gesture.

Read the columns once at their actual size. Leave the week alone.

Stop early if you want. Skip a third person's secret, and a sexual moment you have not both agreed to discuss.



C48 · STORY

Our Greatest Hits

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

Our Greatest Hits

Four columns. A funny story does not have to be the meaningful one.

1. Headings: funniest, most romantic, unexpected, meaningful. Quietly write a slug for each you have: place, the turn, why it plays. Empty stays empty.
2. Take one column at a time. A story may sit in two only if you both agree. Tell the place, the turn, and why it still plays.
3. The listener asks for one extra detail, names what landed, and saves their own story for their turn. If you split on whether it was funny, write both. No vote.
4. Mark keepers you both will retell, one is enough, plus one detail you will stop sanding. Read the headings, empties included.

Then stop, before the hits become a second dinner.

Humiliating a partner, or a friend who is not here, stays off. Stories about sex, bodies, or family need a yes from both.

A nomination can move to a private margin with no case to argue. You may pass a column.



C49 · STORY

The Moment I Saw You Differently

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The Moment I Saw You Differently

Four beats: the smaller picture, the place, the detail that broke it, the wider one.

1. 5 quiet minutes. Sketch the smaller picture without scolding your past self, one scene, the detail that refused to fit, and the wider picture: warmer, stranger, sadder, or more accurate. Not a diagnosis. No detail means pass.
2. Speak the four beats. A minute of quiet before the listener talks.
3. They reflect the change, and may add how it felt inside the scene. They do not grind down the old picture, sweeten it, or perform the quality. A missing memory does not erase the seeing. They need not agree.
4. Switch to a different episode. Close with one line each: what you know now that you could not have known at the start.

Then stop. A tour of every misreading is a different week.

Pass an accusation or an open injury, unless you both want that scene. No third person's secret.



C50 · STORY

The Unspoken Thank-You

The Past, the Present, and the Story of Us

The Unspoken Thank-You

Finish one thanks that lost the race with the week. The cost may be wrong.

1. 8 minutes apart. Three sentences: what they did; what you think it cost them, as a guess; what changed for you. Name the act.
2. Read. The receiver takes it in, and may correct the cost with care. They do not joke it away or answer with a thanks in the same breath.
3. Switch. Size and era need not match. No unpaid thanks you believe is a finished turn: say you looked.

Ask once if a sentence may be kept. A no still leaves the spoken thanks complete. Then stop.

Do not thank a partner for harm endured, silence, or unfair work treated as a gift. A request disguised as thanks gets cut.

If resentment is still tangled in it, pick a smaller finished act or postpone. You may decline a thanks that sweetens a hard period.